

- RAG Learning

3.2 Language and Gender Identity (Paper 3 pathway)

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 3 Investigating Language

Language and Gender Identity studies how gender interacts with linguistic choice. The field has developed through four major frames — **deficit** (Lakoff), **dominance** (Zimmerman & West, Fishman), **difference** (Tannen), and **performativity / community of practice** (Butler, Eckert & McConnell-Ginet, Cameron). A top-band Paper 3 answer moves *across* these frames rather than settling on one.

3.2.1 Deficit Model — Lakoff (1975)

Robin Lakoff's *Language and Woman's Place* proposed that "women's language" is characterised by less-assertive features: **hedges**, **tag questions**, **rising intonation on declaratives**, **empty evaluative adjectives**, **hypercorrect grammar**, **super-polite forms**, **intensifiers**, and avoidance of strong swearing.

Criticism: introspective, not systematic; treats women's language as deviating from a male norm; confounds power with gender.

3.2.2 Dominance Model

Zimmerman & West (1975)

In 31 conversations, men accounted for 96% of interruptions (46 of 48) in mixed dyads — argued for male conversational dominance.

Fishman (1978/1983)

Heterosexual couples' talk at home: women ask nearly 3× as many questions, use minimal responses to sustain topics, and carry most interactional work. Women's topics succeed 36%; men's 96%. Fishman calls this "conversational shitwork".

O'Barr & Atkins (1980)

Courtroom witnesses: Lakoff's features correlate with POWER, not gender. Low-status speakers of either gender use the same features. Renamed **powerless language**. The deficit model confounds gender with power.

3.2.3 Difference Model — Tannen (1990)

Men and women are socialised into different communicative subcultures:

Binary	"Male" style	"Female" style
Orientation	Status	Connection
Talk type	Report talk	Rapport talk
Response	Advice	Understanding
Conflict	Direct	Indirect

3.2.4 Holmes (1992) — Multi-function Tag Questions

Tag questions serve many functions:

- **Epistemic** — checking information ("It's at 3, isn't it?")
- **Facilitative** — inviting response ("Lovely weather, isn't it?")
- **Softening** — mitigating directness ("That's not quite right, is it?")
- **Challenging** — pushing the addressee ("You did call him, didn't you?")

Women use facilitative tags more often than men. Managing interaction, not weakness. Powerful critique of the deficit reading.

3.2.5 Cameron (2007) — The Myth of Mars and Venus

Deborah Cameron argues gender differences are widely **overstated**: meta-analyses show small average differences and large within-gender variation. The "two cultures" narrative erases overlap and can excuse sexist behaviour as misunderstanding. Where differences exist, they emerge from context, power and community of practice — not innate difference.

3.2.6 Butler — Performativity

Judith Butler (1990): gender is not something we HAVE but something we DO through repeated acts. Language is one such act — our linguistic choices help produce our gender identity.

Implications:

- There is no "essential" male or female voice.
- What sounds "feminine" or "masculine" is a socially-recognised performance.
- Non-binary and fluid gender performances are linguistically legible.
- Analysis asks "what gender is being performed?" rather than "who is the speaker?"

3.2.7 Eckert & McConnell-Ginet — Community of Practice

Shift from static gender categories to **communities of practice** — groups cohering around shared practices and goals. Speakers develop linguistic repertoires within these communities.

Accommodates intersectionality — speakers belong to multiple communities, each shaping their idiolect. Gender is one factor among several including class, ethnicity, age, sexuality.

3.2.8 Spender — Man Made Language (1980)

Dale Spender argues English itself, shaped historically by men, encodes male power — generic masculine, lexical asymmetry, naming conventions. Strong form critiqued for determinism, but the observation about lexical bias is widely accepted.

3.2.9 Gendered Lexis and Representation

Type	Examples
Lexical asymmetry	master/mistress; bachelor/spinster; governor/governess
Generic masculine	chairman, mankind, manhole; historical "he" for any person
Marked female forms	female doctor, lady MP, woman writer
Media representation	"shrill", "bossy", "emotional" for women; "assertive", "decisive" for men

3.2.10 Contemporary Debates

- **Singular "they"** — attested since the 14th century; resurging for gender-neutral and non-binary reference.
- **Inclusive lexis** — spokesperson, firefighter, chairperson.
- **Pronoun declarations** — a marker of inclusive practice.
- **Gender-neutral titles** — "Mx" alongside "Mr/Ms".

These are linguistically unremarkable — languages adapt — but often provoke discourses, providing rich data.

Applied Example: A female politician's speech uses hedges, inclusive "we" and rhetorical questions. Lakoff would label these "women's language"; Holmes would note their facilitative function; Cameron would ask whether they are really gendered or part of the speech genre; Butler would ask what kind of political femininity is being performed. Integrating these lenses — rather than choosing one — is what top-band Paper 3 looks like.

3.2.11 How to Analyse a Gender Text at A-Level

1. Identify **specific linguistic features** (not just "men / women talk differently").

2. Consider **multiple frameworks** — deficit, dominance, difference, performativity.
3. Ask about **power and role** (O'Barr & Atkins) — is the feature better explained by status than gender?
4. Consider the **community of practice**.
5. Discuss **representation** — how is gender constructed?
6. Evaluate — avoid essentialism; acknowledge within-gender variation.

Paper 3 Tip: Never reason "speaker is female → feature = women's language". That has been discredited for decades. Top-band Paper 3 answers treat gender as one contextual factor among several and integrate multiple theorists.

Key Terms Checklist

Deficit / dominance / difference / performativity models, hedges, tag questions, uptalk, minimal responses, generic masculine, marked female form, lexical asymmetry, interruption vs supportive overlap, community of practice, report talk / rapport talk, verbal hygiene.
Theorists: **Lakoff, Zimmerman & West, Fishman, O'Barr & Atkins, Tannen, Holmes, Coates, Spender, Cameron, Butler, Eckert & McConnell-Ginet.**